

A telegraph company employee carries out the vital task of repairing the lines. This was dangerous work, often performed under fire from the enemy or in areas where enemy guerrilla fighters operated.

The federal telegraph service

The U.S.M.T.S. was initially reliant on civilian companies, with the government placing it under the control of the Quartermaster Corps. The service was operated by civilian personnel, most of whom were employees of the major telegraph companies before the war, and included a significant percentage of women. Military supervision of an essentially civilian organization caused friction. Major General George Meade frequently complained about the cavalier attitude of telegraphers in the U.S.M.T.S., who occasionally left for home during critical moments of campaigns. By 1864, however, enough trained personnel were employed to maintain a continuous service. During the siege of Petersburg, General Ulysses S. Grant enjoyed almost uninterrupted telegraph communication with both Washington, D.C., and his subcommanders operating throughout the South.

Confederate telegraph services

Two civilian companies operated in the South prior to the war, one of which was the American Telegraph Company. The director of its southern branch was Dr. William S. Morris. In 1862, Postmaster General John H. Reagan made Morris “agent of the Confederate States,” responsible for managing all military telegraph lines in the South. Morris and Reagan shared the duties.

For the first three years of the war, the telegraph allowed Jefferson Davis to keep in close touch with his primary generals, although some of them disliked communicating under the watchful eye of Morris and Reagan. General P. G. T. Beauregard, for example, created his own telegraph system around the Charleston defenses. Rebel snags with the telegraph were primarily caused by supply shortages and raiders.

As Confederate fortunes waned, Southern telegraph operators rose to the challenge and kept the lines humming. During General Sherman’s March to the Sea, Georgia’s agent advised: “Keep your